

dete ho, uski khushi hi alag hoti hai ["There is a different kind of happiness in earning through your hard work and giving it to your family"]," she says. Neeru has also been appointed as a Naib Subedar in the Indian Army, giving her a steady income as well as access to its facilities.

Meanwhile, Neeru is embracing—and clearly relishing—the spotlight. She was jubilant to find a sea of people waiting to receive her when she first landed at the Indira Gandhi International Airport in Delhi, before flying back to Japan for the closing ceremony, where she was the Indian contingent's flag-bearer.

At the India Today Woman Summit in August, she candidly recounted her journey and was thrilled to meet actress Vedika Pinto, one of the stars of *Musafir Cafe*, a show Neeru had binge-watched. "I was like, 'Wow, it is shot in the same café where I have had coffee so many times,'" she said. This is Neeru simply living by her philosophy. "*Ek hi toh life hai* (I have one life to live)," she says, "so I do whatever I like. I watch movies, train with full commitment, make time for friends and hang out with my seniors and juniors."

As the eyeballs on her multiply, so do the expectations, but Neeru seems ready to fire on all cylinders. "The next two years will be spent improving and polishing myself, because there's no end to learning," she says. And, hopefully, for India, no end to her winning ways either. ■

—Suhani Singh

The Longest Run

AS TRAIL RUNNING GAINS GROUND IN INDIA, FASTEST KNOWN TIMES (FKTs) ARE GIVING RUNNERS A NEW WAY TO TEST THEMSELVES—AS SANNAT SACHDEV DISCOVERED ON HIMACHAL'S PUNISHING BIR–BADA BHANGAL TRAIL

On September 18, Sannat Sachdev took on his longest run. The 52.5 km route (elevation gain: 4,300m) between Bir and Bada Bhangal—one of the most remote tribal villages in Himachal Pradesh—is a journey of three to four days, usually undertaken by locals, shepherds or trekkers. He now looked to establish the Fastest Known Time (FKT) on the trail.

Starting out at 4 am, Sachdev, 34, ran a short distance in the company of fellow runners. He navigated steep ascents, river crossings, moraine and snow bridges to arrive at the high-altitude village after 12 hours 12 seconds. "I had to figure out everything from navigation to fuelling on my own," he recalls. "The terrain is technical, then there is the altitude. So, I had to be efficient and consistent in terms of expending energy and resources."

Trail running in India has grown over the past five years, both in terms of the number of races and runners. Access to trails continues to be a challenge, especially for those living in metros. But weekend runs led by clubs such as Sahyadri Scramblers and Capital Trails have enabled road runners to understand the nitty-gritty of trail running.



ON THE TRAIL Sannat Sachdev takes a breather en route to Bada Bhangal in the Dhauladhar

After competing in trail races in India and around the world, Sachdev turned to his first FKT. These attempts got popular during the pandemic lockdown when races were cancelled. Runners picked out routes based on their abilities, an effort that could last a few hours or extend to days. "You can create a unique project in your backyard. And when it's an iconic route, others can challenge your time and keep pushing limits," he explains.

> **Trail running in India has grown over the past five years, getting popular during the pandemic lockdown**

Six hours into the run, fatigue was setting in and the altitude was taking its toll on Sachdev. When he topped out at Thamsar Pass, the highest point on the route, he knew the demanding climbs were behind him. But a tricky descent over rocks and scree followed. "The most miserable two hours of the day...but I was committed and pushed on," he says. The rush was palpable, but with no cellular network, Sachdev was left to savour the moment in the company of the breathtaking Dhauladhar mountains. ■

—Shail Desai